

THRONES BUILT ON SAND

When Empires Forget What Holds Them Up



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By Sonia Benjoye

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Epigraph

A throne built on sand will fall the moment its foundation is forgotten.

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Chapter One

Proclamation at the Height

They said the square had never been so full. From the palace steps to the market gates, there was no room to walk without brushing against another body. Flags hung from every window. The air was thick with the smell of cooked meat, dust, and the sweat of thousands who had been standing for hours. The drums had been sounding since sunrise, steady and relentless, a reminder to the city that this was no ordinary gathering.

At the center of it all stood the throne. Raised on a platform high enough for even the people at the edges of the crowd to see, it glimmered under the sun. It was not the old wooden seat used by the rulers before. This was new. Carved from imported stone. Inlaid with gold. Built to outlast the hands that would hold it.

The ruler walked out slowly, each step deliberate. The crowd roared but he did not smile. His robe was heavy, layered, almost like armor. The crown caught the sunlight, sending shards of light into the eyes of the people below. When he reached the throne, he did not sit. Instead, he stood before it, hands resting on the carved armrests, and raised his head.

The proclamation began. His voice carried over the square, amplified by the silence that spread like a wave from the front to the back. He declared the kingdom unbreakable. He spoke of strength, of expansion, of a future so certain it did not need to be questioned. He named himself the builder of a new age and promised that the city's name would be spoken for a thousand years. The people cheered as if the promise was already fulfilled.

What no one noticed was how the platform beneath the throne swayed slightly when the crowd shifted. Or how the men who built it had been paid less than they were promised. Or how the grain shipments had been late for weeks because the bridges to the outer farms were in disrepair. Those details did not fit into the story being told from the steps. They were small truths, and small truths do not belong in proclamations.

The need for this day had been growing for months. There had been unrest in the southern provinces, disputes over land in the east, and quiet complaints about new taxes. Trade was slowing, but the palace had forbidden any mention of it in public. The proclamation was not only for the people. It was for the governors and generals who had begun to ask too many questions. It was meant to remind them that power still sat firmly in the capital, that the crown was still the center of the world.

From the edge of the square, an advisor named Harun watched the ruler speak. He had been with him since the early campaigns, back when their meetings were in candle-lit rooms and the crown was still a dream. Harun noticed the weight in the ruler's voice. It was not the weight of leadership but the weight of someone who must keep believing in his own words,

or risk the people doubting them too. Harun also noticed something else: the absence of three key governors, each claiming illness that morning. It was the first time they had missed a proclamation. It would not be the last.

When the speeches ended, the ruler finally sat. The cheers reached a final peak before dissolving into the noise of the market reopening. The soldiers began clearing the square, not with force, but with presence. The ruler was taken inside. Wine and roasted meat awaited him in the council chamber, along with the ministers who had crafted the very words he spoke. They congratulated him, praised his delivery, promised him the people were united. He accepted the words but not the truth behind them. He knew that unity was as fragile as the mood of the crowd, and moods could shift without warning.

Behind the chamber doors, the conversation turned. Reports came in of shortages in the west. An envoy from the northern mines asked for more soldiers to protect the roads. One minister warned that the treasury reserves were lower than expected. The ruler waved away the warnings. This was not the day for bad news. Let the record show that the city was whole and the throne unshakable. The rest could wait.

Later, when the day's heat had given way to the cool of evening, Harun wrote in his private journal: *"Today we reached the height of the throne. I do not know if there is anywhere to go from here but down."*

Weeks later, whispers began to circulate in the taverns near the docks. Some said the crown had ordered the proclamation to hide a weakness. Others claimed the missing governors were not ill but meeting in secret. None of it could be proven. None of it made the official records. But those who kept track of such things marked the day.

History would remember the proclamation as the most triumphant day of his reign. What history would not remember is that triumph has a shadow. And on that day, the shadow had already begun to grow.

The night after the proclamation the palace stayed lit long after the rest of the city had gone dark. The wine cellars were opened, the musicians played, and the servants moved quickly to keep the tables full. The ruler entertained foreign envoys who had travelled for days to attend the event. They bowed, spoke their rehearsed blessings, and promised loyalty in exchange for favors that would be discussed in private chambers later. The air in the great hall was heavy with the smell of roasted meat and perfume.

In the smaller council rooms away from the noise the conversations were sharper. Generals spoke in low voices about the growing strength of the border kingdoms. Merchants asked when the crown would address the tariffs that had slowed trade. Harun stayed close to the ruler but said little. He had learned that a man at the height of his power does not want to hear what could make him doubt it.

At midnight the ruler dismissed the last of the guests and walked the empty corridors alone. The guards followed at a distance. He paused at a window overlooking the square where hours earlier thousands had cheered his name. The torches had been put out. The streets were empty. In the silence he could almost believe it had been a dream.

By morning the city had returned to its routine. Markets opened, ships docked, and the work of carrying the empire forward continued in the hands of people who would never see the inside of the palace. They did not speak of proclamations. They spoke of grain prices, broken carts, and sick children. In their world the height of the throne was a distant event, remembered only when it touched their daily lives.

The record keepers in the palace archives wrote only of the crowds, the applause, and the words spoken from the platform. The unrest in the southern provinces, the missing governors, the late shipments of grain, all remained in separate files marked for internal eyes only. Years later historians would call this day the moment the empire was at its strongest. The documents that would have shown otherwise stayed locked in rooms no one outside the palace would ever enter.

Harun would remember it differently. To him it was the day the ruler began to believe in the image more than the reality. It was the day the crown started to depend on the theatre of power rather than the strength beneath it.

In the weeks that followed, the image of the proclamation was carefully preserved. Painters were commissioned to capture the moment the ruler stood before the throne. Copies of the speech were sent to every province with instructions that it be read aloud in the main square of each capital. Messengers were told to record the reactions of the crowds. Any sign of disinterest or complaint was to be noted and reported directly to the palace.

Inside the city the signs of strain began to surface. Merchants complained quietly that the cost of transporting goods had risen. Farmers arriving from the outer lands spoke of bandits on the roads and repairs left unfinished on the bridges. The news did not travel far beyond the markets because the city's guards had orders to stop any public gatherings that could turn into complaints. The ruler wanted the proclamation to live in memory as the start of a golden age, not the opening of a slow decline.

Harun watched all of it from a careful distance. He attended council meetings where voices clashed over priorities. Some argued for strengthening the army, others for repairing the infrastructure that kept trade moving. The ruler listened, nodded, and gave vague instructions that pleased no one completely. He had begun to think of the empire as a structure that could stand on appearances alone. The councillors who had known him in the early years understood this was dangerous, but few dared to challenge him directly. Those who did found themselves posted to distant provinces or given tasks that kept them away from the capital.

Beyond the city walls the people who had cheered during the proclamation saw little change in their lives. A family in the eastern farmlands still struggled to bring enough water to their crops. Traders at the western docks still argued with customs officers over the new taxes. The proclamation was not discussed there anymore. It was replaced in conversation by the price of salt, the condition of the roads, and the latest rumors about tensions in the north.

By the end of the season the glow of the great day had faded for everyone except the ruler. In his mind the proclamation was proof that the empire was secure. It was the moment he thought of when doubts crept in. It became his shield against warnings and his answer to every question. He would recall the sound of the crowd, the sight of the raised flags, and believe it was enough to hold everything together.

The record in the palace archives for this period contains only two entries. The first is the official account of the day, describing the celebration and the unity of the people. The second, sealed and unsigned, is a single sentence written in the margins of a report on grain shortages. It reads, The higher we build the throne, the less we see the sand beneath it.

Chapter Two

Year 47: The Poison Banquet

The banquet was announced as a celebration of victory. After months of unrest in the northern provinces, the rebellion had been crushed, and the ruler wanted the court to see him surrounded by his most loyal governors and generals. Invitations were sent weeks in advance, each one sealed with the gold emblem of the crown. Refusing to attend would have been read as open defiance.

The great hall was transformed for the occasion. Long tables were set with imported silverware, tall candles, and trays of fruit brought from lands most of the guests had never seen. Musicians played near the walls, their soft melodies meant to keep the air light. The scent of roasted meat drifted through the room. Every detail had been arranged to send a single message: the empire was stable, and its ruler was unshaken.

From the start, the evening felt tense. Conversations at the lower tables were cautious. The rebellion in the north had not been entirely defeated, and everyone knew it. Reports from the front were inconsistent, and rumors of unrest in the east were already spreading. But none of that was mentioned openly. The official story was one of complete victory, and no one dared to disrupt it in the ruler's presence.

Harun was seated close to the ruler's table, close enough to hear the low exchanges between him and his closest ministers. They spoke in fragments, breaking off whenever servants approached. Harun noticed the absence of two provincial governors who had been instrumental in quelling the northern unrest. Their absence was explained as illness, but Harun doubted it. He had learned that in this court, absence was rarely a matter of health.

As the night went on, the toasts began. Each governor stood to praise the ruler, recounting his wisdom and courage. The ruler accepted the compliments with small nods, lifting his cup each time. By the fourth toast, Harun saw the first sign that something was wrong. The commander of the eastern garrison, a man with a reputation for both loyalty and bluntness, hesitated before drinking. He set his cup down, smiled faintly, and excused himself from the table. He did not return.

Within the hour, three other guests left in similar fashion, pale and unsteady. Servants were told to clear their plates quietly. No one at the high table mentioned it, but the tension grew heavier with each departure. Harun caught the eye of the chief steward, who gave the smallest shake of his head. It was the kind of signal that meant nothing to the record but everything to those who understood the palace's unspoken language.

By the time the final course was served, the ruler's expression had changed. The easy confidence he had worn earlier was gone, replaced by a guarded stillness. He raised his cup

only when others were watching and took smaller sips. The music played on, the candles burned low, but the warmth of the banquet had drained away. When the last guest departed, the hall was left in silence except for the footsteps of servants clearing the tables.

The official record of the banquet describes it as a night of unity and celebration. It notes the quality of the wine, the richness of the food, and the generosity of the ruler's hospitality. There is no mention of the men who fell ill before the night ended or the quiet investigations that began the following morning.

In Harun's private account, he writes that the banquet marked the moment when the ruler began to doubt those seated closest to him. He could no longer tell which hands raised in toast were also capable of pouring poison. Trust, once broken in the court, could never be rebuilt to its former strength. From that night forward, the throne stood not in the center of a court, but in the center of a circle of suspicion.

The morning after the banquet, the palace corridors were unusually quiet. Servants moved quickly, keeping their eyes lowered, as if avoiding attention could keep them out of whatever was unfolding. By midday, the news reached Harun in fragments. The commander of the eastern garrison had not survived the night. Two governors remained bedridden, guarded by their own men who refused to let palace physicians near them. A third man, a wealthy merchant with long-standing ties to the court, had left the city before dawn without permission.

The ruler convened the council in the smaller war chamber, the one without windows. He arrived without the usual formalities, his crown absent, his robe plain. The first words he spoke were not of grief but of control. "No one speaks of last night beyond these walls," he ordered. The ministers nodded, though Harun noticed some were slower to agree than others. One of them, a senior advisor from the coastal provinces, asked directly if the ruler believed the banquet had been targeted. The ruler gave no answer.

That afternoon, the palace guard quietly sealed the wine cellars and dismissed half the kitchen staff. Interrogations began, starting with the servants who had poured the drinks. Some confessed to nothing. Others claimed ignorance. One young cupbearer swore he had been instructed to change the serving order at the last moment, replacing the goblets meant for the ruler with those meant for the governors. His statement was taken, sealed, and never mentioned again.

Beyond the palace, rumors moved faster than the official silence. In the markets, they whispered that the poison was not meant for the governors at all but for the ruler himself. Others claimed it was a test by the ruler, a way to see who would drink without hesitation. No one knew for certain, and in the absence of certainty, suspicion spread like disease.

In the weeks that followed, the court began to fracture in subtle ways. Governors travelled with larger entourages, dining only with those they trusted. The ruler began to summon people to private audiences more frequently, bypassing the full council. Harun saw the

change in him, a constant scanning of faces, an edge in his voice when speaking to men he had once called friends. The open laughter that had once filled the council hall was replaced by short, measured exchanges.

The official version of events, recorded in the royal archives, preserved the banquet as a grand celebration marking the end of northern unrest. No illness was noted, no deaths recorded for that date. The only surviving clue to the truth was an unsigned note, found years later in a locked drawer of the steward's desk. It read: "The crown did not drink."

Harun's own account ended with a line that the archivists never copied: "From that night, the throne was no longer the center of the empire. It was the center of a siege."

In the months that followed, the banquet became a ghost in every conversation. No one spoke of it directly, but its shadow was always there. Every smile in the council chamber seemed tighter, every agreement carried a pause before the final word. Old alliances weakened, replaced by short-term arrangements built on convenience rather than trust.

The ruler began dining alone more often. When he did eat in company, he insisted his food be prepared in his private kitchens and tasted by men whose loyalty had been proven over years. The wine cups were no longer shared. Each guest drank from a vessel poured and guarded in their presence.

The governors returned to their provinces with polite farewells, but Harun saw the distance in their eyes. They had come to the capital expecting celebration and left with the certainty that danger now lived inside the palace itself. What had once been the heart of the empire was becoming a place they visited only when they had no choice.

The archives for Year 47 end with a single note, written in the steady hand of the court historian: "The empire stands united." It was a sentence meant for the eyes of the future, but anyone living through that year would have known the truth. Unity had left the room the night the poison touched the cups, and it had not returned.

Harun kept his own record, sealed away where no official could reach it. In it, he wrote: *"It is not the fall itself that begins the end. It is the day trust dies. From that moment, the crown rules in name only."*

Chapter Three

Year 2: The Birth of the Builder

Year Two was not marked by celebration or ceremony. It was marked by work. The man who would one day sit on the throne had not yet been called ruler. He was known only as Commander of the Southern Guard, a title earned through discipline more than heritage. His uniform was plain. His boots were often covered in dust from the border roads. He spoke little and observed much.

The capital at that time was smaller, its outer walls cracked from years of neglect. The market district was overcrowded, and the docks were too shallow for larger ships. The treasury held enough coin to run the city for a season, but no more. Most of the governors served only their own provinces and avoided being called to the capital. Authority existed in name but not in reach.

The man who would be ruler began to change that quietly. He traveled to the outer provinces with only a small escort, meeting with local leaders without the weight of a royal court behind him. He listened to complaints about trade routes, water supplies, and unpaid soldiers. When he returned to the capital, he did not call for speeches. He called for repairs. Roads were cleared. Bridges were reinforced. Taxes were collected more evenly, and part of the revenue was used where it had been taken from, something the people had not seen in years.

By the middle of Year Two, his name began to carry weight in the provinces. Soldiers from distant garrisons asked to serve under his command. Merchants who had avoided the capital for years began returning, bringing goods and coin that had been going elsewhere. The old guard in the council took notice. Some respected him for the results. Others saw him as a threat.

The turning point came in the late months of that year, when the northern provinces faced a severe drought. Grain shipments from the central farmlands had been promised but never arrived, delayed by corruption in the transport offices. Without public announcement, the commander took a convoy of carts north, escorted by his own men. He distributed the grain himself, keeping no record for the treasury to manipulate. The gesture spread by word of mouth faster than any official decree. For the people of the north, it was the first time in years that the capital had acted in their interest.

The sitting ruler at that time, an aging monarch with little patience for provincial politics, summoned the commander to explain his actions. It was expected that he would be reprimanded for overstepping authority. Instead, the old monarch kept him in the council

chambers for hours, asking questions about the state of the provinces. By the end of the meeting, the commander was appointed overseer of infrastructure, a position that placed him in control of the empire's roads, ports, and supply lines.

Harun, then a young scribe in the council records office, remembered the day clearly. He wrote in his private notes that it was the first time the council had fallen silent not out of respect, but because they understood that something irreversible had begun. The man now held the veins of the empire in his hands. Whoever controlled the flow of goods and soldiers controlled the heart of the kingdom.

By the close of Year Two, the foundations of power had shifted. The monarch still wore the crown, but the commander had begun building something far more lasting than a title. He was not yet called ruler, but those who watched closely already knew the truth. The builder had begun his work.

The appointment as overseer of infrastructure changed the commander's daily life immediately. He no longer answered to the lesser ministers who had controlled the treasury's flow. Instead, he reported directly to the monarch, bypassing the slow network of bureaucracy that had kept the provinces starved of resources for years. This made him efficient, but it also made him dangerous in the eyes of those who had benefited from the old delays.

Within weeks, he began visiting sites that no minister had inspected in decades. He walked the broken edges of the western bridge, speaking with the men who risked their lives crossing it with carts of goods. He stood at the shallow docks of the southern port, calculating how much stone would be needed to deepen them for larger ships. Everywhere he went, he made notes, spoke with local leaders, and gave instructions that were carried out before he left. It was a pace of governance the provinces were not used to, and it unsettled the council members who preferred slow negotiations and profitable contracts.

Harun, who had been assigned to accompany him on many of these visits, observed how he worked. The commander listened more than he spoke. When he gave orders, they were short and direct. He did not carry scribes to record every detail for the archives, and he rarely brought a full guard unless the journey required it. This gave him an air of approachability that made farmers and traders speak freely in his presence. It also gave him a reputation among the elite as someone who ignored the formalities that kept power concentrated in the capital.

By the harvest season of Year Two, his changes were visible. The western bridge was reinforced with new stone, the southern docks could now hold double the number of ships, and the main road from the central farmlands to the capital had been cleared of the bandits who had plagued it for years. These were not projects that earned applause in the throne room, but they earned loyalty in the streets and marketplaces.

The council began to split into two camps. One group saw him as the future of the empire, someone capable of restoring strength to a system that had been hollowed by neglect. The other viewed him as an upstart whose influence was growing too quickly. That second group began quietly re-establishing alliances, using gifts and promises to keep governors loyal to the old order. The rivalry between these two camps was not yet open, but it would become the defining struggle of the decades to come.

The monarch seemed unaware of the growing divide, or perhaps unwilling to confront it. He saw only the results. Grain reached the provinces on time. Trade taxes began to rise as more merchants passed through the capital. The treasury was replenished enough to fund a new wing in the palace. He credited the commander for all of it, but the praise only deepened the resentment among those who had been sidelined.

In his private journal, Harun noted a meeting late in the year where the commander presented his plans for the next decade of infrastructure improvements. He laid out the routes for new roads, the strengthening of border fortresses, and the expansion of the northern ports to open new trade with distant kingdoms. No one in the room disputed the logic of the plan, but Harun saw the unease in their faces. It was not the vision they feared, but the man delivering it.

By the end of Year Two, the commander's name carried more weight than many of the seated governors. Farmers in the provinces spoke of him with gratitude. Merchants spoke of him with respect. His enemies in the council spoke of him with caution. The crown still rested on the monarch's head, but the work of building a new empire had already begun, and the man behind it was no longer just a commander. He was becoming the builder the chronicles would one day name.

The first open act of resistance came quietly. It was in the northern highlands, where work had begun on a new trade road that would shorten the journey between the mining towns and the capital by almost half. The project had been approved directly by the monarch, but weeks into construction the workers began leaving in small groups. Some claimed the pay had stopped. Others said they had been threatened by men they did not recognize.

When the commander arrived to inspect the site, he found half-built stretches of road abandoned, tools left scattered in the dirt. The foreman, a man appointed by the council, told him supplies had been delayed and wages had been redirected for "more urgent matters" in the capital. The commander did not argue. He dismissed the foreman on the spot, posted two of his own officers in his place, and ordered the wages paid from his own military funds until the treasury released the official payment.

Three days later, one of the supply caravans was set upon in broad daylight by a group of armed riders. They made no attempt to take the goods. Instead, they burned the carts where they stood, leaving the road impassable. The commander sent a patrol to track them but

returned with no captives. Witnesses claimed the riders had worn no insignia, but their weapons were of a style commonly used by soldiers stationed in the central provinces.

Harun, who was present for the inspection of the burned carts, wrote that the commander stood for several minutes looking at the ashes before speaking. When he did, it was not to accuse or threaten. He simply ordered the road rebuilt, starting that day, and doubled the guard until it was complete.

By the end of the season, the road was finished. The mining towns began sending caravans to the capital, and the trade route became one of the most profitable in the empire. The sabotage was never officially investigated, and no one in the council asked about it again. But the message was clear to those who understood the court's hidden games. The commander could not be stopped with small acts of disruption. If he was to be brought down, it would require far more than burned carts and frightened workers.

Harun's final entry for Year Two was short but telling. "The builder's work stands," he wrote, "and now those who fear him know it will take more than whispers to bring it down."

Chapter Four

Year 51: The Great Betrayal

By Year 51, the throne stood higher than it had in living memory. The empire's borders stretched farther than the maps of the old monarchs. Trade routes reached into kingdoms that had once been enemies. The ruler, now decades into his reign, was both respected and feared in equal measure. His early works as the builder were still spoken of with admiration, but the man himself had changed.

Power had aged him. His once deliberate speech had become sharper, sometimes cutting. His circle had grown smaller, not out of choice but out of necessity. Years of surviving court politics had stripped away his trust in most of the governors who sat at his table. Decisions that once passed through open council were now made behind the doors of his private chamber, often with only Harun and a handful of loyal ministers present.

It was in this climate that the betrayal began. The first sign came as a rumor — nothing unusual for a court that thrived on whispers. Reports reached the capital that two border provinces had failed to send their annual tribute. At first, it was dismissed as a delay caused by poor weather or disputes among local officials. But then a caravan sent to collect the tribute returned empty, the guards wounded, and the leader dead. They claimed the provincial governors had declared themselves independent, forming an alliance that would no longer answer to the capital.

The ruler's reaction was measured but cold. He summoned the governors of the remaining provinces to the capital for an emergency council. All but two arrived. The missing names were those of the very men accused of breaking away. Their absence confirmed the truth of the rebellion.

What made the betrayal great was not that two provinces had turned against the throne. Rebellions were not new to the empire. What made it great was the revelation that the governors had been aided by members of the ruler's own inner circle. Men who had sat with him in council for decades, men who had toasted his victories and sworn loyalty before the court, had been working in secret to weaken him.

The first to be accused was the Treasurer of the Capital, a man whose influence reached every corner of the empire's finances. Records uncovered by the palace guard showed years of discreetly diverting funds to the rebel provinces, disguised as trade subsidies. The second was the Commander of the Eastern Fleet, who had allowed ships carrying weapons to pass unchecked into rebel ports.

When confronted, both denied the charges. The treasurer claimed the records were forgeries planted by rivals. The fleet commander insisted his orders had come directly from

the council, not from the rebels. But the evidence was strong enough to convince the ruler. The treasurer was imprisoned without trial. The commander fled the city before an arrest could be made, disappearing into the southern provinces.

Harun wrote that the ruler's anger was unlike anything he had seen before. It was not loud. It was not theatrical. It was cold, precise, and aimed not at the rebels but at the court itself. He began a purge of the council, dismissing anyone whose loyalty he could not personally guarantee. Ministers who had served for decades found themselves replaced by younger, untested men who owed their positions entirely to the ruler's favor. The change was swift, but it left the government unstable, its leadership inexperienced in managing the far provinces.

Outside the capital, the rebellion gained strength. The provinces that remained loyal did so more out of fear than devotion. Trade slowed. The treasury's reserves began to shrink. And still, the ruler refused to call the betrayal by its true name in any official record. In the archives, the events of Year 51 were marked only as "The Provincial Dispute," a phrase so mild it almost erased the reality of what had happened.

In Harun's private journal, the entry for that year was longer than any before it. "The betrayal was not the breaking away of provinces," he wrote. "It was the day the ruler understood that the walls around him were not built to keep out his enemies. They were built to keep him inside."

The political cost of the betrayal was heavier than the loss of the rebel provinces. The purge left the council without its most experienced voices. Negotiations with foreign envoys stalled because the new ministers lacked the skill to navigate long-standing agreements. Treaties that had been in place for decades began to unravel quietly, replaced by temporary arrangements that favored the other side.

In the provinces, governors who had remained loyal began to question whether loyalty still served their interests. Some demanded greater autonomy in exchange for their continued support. Others delayed sending tribute, forcing the palace to choose between enforcing its will through force or accepting reduced authority in practice. Each concession weakened the image of central power.

The rebels understood this and used it to their advantage. They sent messages to wavering governors offering trade without taxes, protection without interference, and most dangerously a voice in the shaping of a new order. For governors who had long resented the capital's control, the temptation was strong.

Inside the palace, the ruler tightened his grip. Harun described the period as one where the council chamber became less a place of governance and more a fortress of survival. Decisions were no longer about the good of the empire but about preserving the seat of power in the capital. The ruler had once been a builder, but by Year 51, he had become a defender of walls that were already cracking.

The official record closed the year with the words, "The throne remains unshaken." In truth, the throne still stood because those who might take it had not yet agreed on who should sit there. That was not strength. That was a pause before the next blow.

Harun's final note for the year was brief. "The betrayal was not a single act. It is a condition. And once it begins, it does not end until the throne is empty."

Chapter Five

Year 33: The Disappearance of the Bridge

The bridge had stood for nearly a century. It spanned the wide river that cut through the eastern provinces, linking the rich farmland on one side to the trade ports on the other. Without it, grain, salt, and timber would have to travel days out of the way, passing through smaller roads that were never built to carry the weight of an empire's commerce. The bridge was more than stone and mortar. It was a lifeline.

When the message arrived in the capital that the bridge had "disappeared," it was dismissed at first as an exaggeration. Bridges do not vanish. But within days, merchants began arriving at the gates with empty carts, their goods spoiled or abandoned. The story was the same from all of them. The bridge had not fallen from age or storm. It had been dismantled.

The initial report from the governor of the eastern provinces claimed the collapse was caused by structural weakness. But when Harun read the full account, it became clear the explanation was thin. There had been no flooding that season, no earthquake, no signs of decay reported in previous years. Instead, the stones had been removed in sections, starting at the far end and working inward, leaving nothing but bare supports jutting from the water.

The ruler summoned the governor to the capital, demanding to know who had ordered the dismantling. The governor's answers shifted with each question. At first, he blamed local thieves who stripped the bridge for stone to sell. Then he claimed it had been the work of rebels trying to disrupt trade. Finally, under pressure, he admitted that he had authorized the removal himself, claiming the bridge had become unsafe.

It was Harun who pieced together the truth. The dismantling was not about safety. It was about control. In the months before the bridge disappeared, the governor had been negotiating with merchant families in the southern ports. By removing the bridge, he forced all eastern trade to flow south through his allies' territory, where higher tariffs could be charged. The profits were shared quietly, split between the governor and the merchant houses.

The ruler's response was swift but complicated. Removing the governor risked alienating the merchant families whose wealth was critical to the empire's treasury. Leaving him in place signaled to other governors that they could undermine the infrastructure of the state without consequence. The council was split. The ministers responsible for finance argued for compromise. The ministers responsible for security demanded removal.

In the end, the ruler chose a half-measure. The governor was stripped of authority over transport and trade but allowed to remain in his post. The bridge was ordered rebuilt, though this would take years. In the meantime, the eastern provinces suffered. Farmers

struggled to move their crops. Prices in the capital rose as supplies slowed. The ports in the south grew richer than ever, their loyalty increasingly tied not to the crown, but to the man who had made them powerful.

Harun recorded the political cost in blunt terms. "A bridge can be rebuilt. Trust cannot. And when the structures that hold an empire together are dismantled for private gain, the damage is not measured in stone, but in the quiet shift of power away from the throne."

Rebuilding the bridge took longer than the ruler had promised. The original engineers were gone, and the skilled masons who had worked on it decades earlier had either died or moved to the rebel provinces. The reconstruction was slowed further by disputes over funding. Each season, the governor of the eastern provinces found a reason to delay sending the workers and materials needed. Officially, the delays were blamed on shortages. In reality, the trade through the southern ports was so profitable that no one with influence in the region had an interest in seeing the bridge restored quickly.

In the capital, the council began to feel the strain. Revenue from the eastern grain trade had dropped sharply, forcing the treasury to raise taxes elsewhere. This fueled resentment in the central and northern provinces, where the people saw no benefit from paying more while the easterners and southern ports grew richer. Ministers who raised this issue were accused of undermining unity and were quietly removed from their positions.

Over time, the southern merchant families acted less like subjects of the crown and more like independent rulers. They established their own tariffs, set their own shipping rules, and began using private guards on their docks, answerable only to them. The ruler could still summon them to the capital, but each visit became a negotiation rather than a command. They brought gifts and polite words, but they no longer treated royal orders as law.

Harun wrote that the disappearance of the bridge was the moment the crown lost its monopoly on the empire's arteries of trade. For centuries, roads, rivers, and crossings had been the veins through which the capital's authority flowed. By allowing one governor and a handful of merchants to control a key point of connection, the throne had signaled that power could be taken, not just given.

The effects were still felt years later. The rebuilt bridge eventually stood again, but by then the southern ports had secured long-term agreements with foreign traders. The eastern provinces had learned they could survive and even thrive without direct reliance on the capital. The empire's map had not changed, but its loyalties had.

The official archives record Year 33 as the year of "strategic infrastructure renewal." The phrase was crafted to hide the truth from future generations. Harun's private account tells it plainly: "The bridge was not lost to time or disaster. It was taken apart, stone by stone, by the hands of those meant to guard it. And with it, a piece of the empire's foundation was carried away."

Chapter Six

Year 1: The Sand Beneath Us

Year One was before the throne, before the grand proclamations, before the walls of the capital gleamed with imported stone. It was the year when the foundations of power were still forming, unseen by most. The empire existed in name, but in practice it was a loose collection of provinces tied together by habit rather than authority.

The capital was smaller then, its streets narrow and worn. The palace was a fortress of dark stone built for defense, not ceremony. The council chamber held a long table that could seat twenty, though often fewer than half the seats were filled. Governors came when it suited them, bringing demands rather than tribute. The monarch at the time was aging and content to leave most decisions to ministers whose loyalty could be purchased more easily than earned.

The man who would one day become ruler began his rise in this climate. At that point, he held no royal title. He was a military officer with a reputation for discipline and a habit of speaking plainly in a court where most preferred the safety of polite words. He was not yet seen as a threat, which gave him freedom to move quietly and observe the weaknesses no one else bothered to address.

Harun, still a junior scribe then, later wrote that Year One was when the future ruler first understood that power was not about crowns or titles. It was about control of the things no one thought to protect. Roads, food stores, loyal soldiers—these were the real levers of authority, and most of them were in disrepair.

The weaknesses were everywhere. In the western provinces, river crossings were left unguarded, allowing smugglers to move freely without paying tariffs. In the north, border fortresses stood empty, their walls crumbling. Grain warehouses in the central farmlands were controlled by local families who sold to the highest bidder, whether inside or outside the empire. These gaps did not appear suddenly. They were the result of years of neglect, each small failure sinking deeper into the empire's structure like water into sand.

While the monarch's council argued over ceremonial disputes, the officer began building alliances outside the capital. He offered help to provincial commanders struggling with limited supplies. He arranged for shipments of grain to reach garrisons before winter, even when it meant drawing from his own stores. Each act was recorded in the minds of those who benefited, creating a network of quiet loyalty that owed nothing to the throne and everything to him.

The politics of the capital were no less unstable. Ministers competed for influence, forming temporary alliances that dissolved as soon as the balance shifted. Corruption was not

hidden but accepted as part of the system. Contracts for public works went to the highest briber, not the most capable builder. When these projects failed or were abandoned, the treasury absorbed the loss while the responsible minister moved on to the next profitable scheme.

Harun observed that the officer rarely confronted these failures directly in the council. Instead, he noted who was responsible, who had benefited, and who had been left weakened. By the end of Year One, he had a clear understanding of the true structure of power: it rested not on the palace walls, but on unstable ground, the sand beneath everything.

The official archives of Year One list only minor events: routine inspections, small skirmishes on the borders, and the appointment of new ministers. Nothing in the record suggests that a shift in the empire's future was underway. Yet those who were close enough to see the officer's movements knew differently.

Harun's private account of that year ends with a single observation: "The ground beneath the throne was already loose. All that remained was for someone to see it and begin shaping it to hold their own weight."

The first real test came from the southern provinces. A dispute had broken out between two governors over the rights to a section of farmland along their shared border. The land itself was not especially valuable, but the river that cut through it was. Whoever controlled the land controlled the water rights for hundreds of farms downstream.

The matter was brought to the capital for arbitration. The monarch showed little interest, leaving it to the council to resolve. The ministers began their usual routine of delays, hoping both sides would offer bribes in exchange for a favorable ruling. Weeks passed, and the dispute deepened. Farmers along the river stopped planting, waiting to see who would control the water. Trade slowed as caravans avoided the unsettled region.

The officer saw an opening. Without formal authority, he requested permission to travel to the disputed land as a military observer. The council approved, believing it was a harmless assignment. When he arrived, he met separately with each governor, listening to their arguments without revealing his own intentions. He inspected the farmland, the riverbanks, and the nearby towns. He also met privately with the farmers themselves, asking what they needed most to restore their livelihoods.

The solution he proposed was simple but decisive. He ordered the construction of a new irrigation channel upstream, diverting water in a way that supplied both provinces equally. He arranged for soldiers from his own command to guard the project until it was completed, ensuring neither governor could interfere. When the work was done, the farmers resumed planting, and trade along the river recovered within a month.

Both governors claimed victory in the dispute, each telling their own people that they had secured the water. The truth was that the officer had taken the river out of their control entirely. It now ran through a system maintained by his soldiers, with loyalty to him, not the governors or the council.

When he returned to the capital, the council praised him for ending the conflict without bloodshed. The monarch rewarded him with a ceremonial medal, thinking the matter closed. Harun, however, recorded the deeper meaning. The officer had just claimed control over a strategic resource without a single battle. The water that fed the southern provinces now flowed through channels guarded in his name.

From that moment, provincial leaders began to view him differently. He was no longer just a military officer. He was a man who could solve problems faster than the council and without the cost of endless negotiations. Harun would later write that this was the first stone laid in the unseen foundation that would one day hold the throne.

The official archives marked the southern water dispute as a minor provincial matter resolved without violence. In the records, it occupied less than a page. But in the private notes of those who understood the court, it was seen as the moment the balance began to shift.

By the end of Year One, the officer's influence stretched farther than most realized. He had loyal soldiers stationed in key locations under the guise of guarding projects. He had farmers in multiple provinces who owed him their livelihoods. He had learned how to act within the system while quietly building one of his own beneath it.

The capital remained unaware or unwilling to acknowledge the change. The monarch sat in the council chamber, hearing disputes and approving decrees, believing his authority untouched. But the sand beneath the throne had begun to shift, grain by grain, and it was no longer moving in his favor.

Harun ended his account of the year with a line that would only make sense decades later: "The ground had not yet given way, but the weight was already there."

Chapter Seven

Year 52: The Night the Walls Fell

It began with the sound of bells. Not the slow tolling used for ceremonies, but the rapid ringing that meant the city was under threat. In the capital, bells were not rung without cause. By the time most people stepped into the streets, soldiers were already moving through the main avenues, shouting for the gates to be secured.

The outer wall had been breached. It was not an enemy army that had done it, but years of neglect. The section that gave way was on the eastern side, where the stone had been patched too many times with cheaper materials. Heavy rain in the previous week had loosened the foundation. When it finally collapsed, it left an opening wide enough for a dozen men to walk through side by side.

The immediate danger came not from foreign invaders but from the chaos inside the city. Merchants rushed to move their goods deeper into the inner districts. Families abandoned their homes near the breach. Some citizens took advantage of the confusion, breaking into warehouses and storehouses before the guard could respond.

The ruler, now in the later years of his reign, arrived at the inner gate with his personal guard. Harun, standing with the senior officers, saw that the ruler was angrier than he had been in years. But the anger was not directed at the damage. It was directed at the politics behind it.

The maintenance of the eastern wall had been under the control of the Minister of Fortifications, a position awarded three years earlier to the cousin of a provincial governor. The appointment had been political, not based on skill. Reports about the wall's condition had been sent to the council multiple times. Each time, repairs were postponed so the funds could be redirected to other projects favored by the minister's allies. The collapse was not an accident. It was the result of deliberate neglect.

Inside the council chamber, the ministers argued over how to respond. Some demanded immediate punishment for the Minister of Fortifications. Others warned that removing him would anger his cousin, whose province supplied a third of the army's recruits. The debate revealed how fragile the alliances within the empire had become. Even in the face of a direct threat to the capital, political calculations outweighed decisive action.

The ruler ordered the breach repaired immediately, but that required stone and labor from provinces whose governors now saw an opportunity. The governor of the western mines offered stone at double the usual price. The southern provinces agreed to send workers, but only if certain trade restrictions were lifted. What should have been a matter of urgency turned into a bargaining table, with each side seeking to profit from the crisis.

For weeks, the gap in the wall remained open. The ruler's guard patrolled the breach day and night, but their presence did not restore confidence. Traders avoided the capital, fearing further instability. Prices in the markets rose sharply. The people began to question whether the crown could still protect them.

When the repairs were finally completed, the wall was stronger than before, but the damage to the ruler's authority could not be patched so easily. The breach had shown the people how quickly the safety of the capital could be compromised, and how the council would argue while the city stood exposed.

In the official archives, the event was described as the "Storm Incident," with no mention of political failures. Harun's account was less forgiving. "The night the walls fell was not the night of the breach," he wrote. "It was the night we saw the court hesitate while the city stood open."

The repairs to the wall did not end the crisis. In the weeks after the breach was closed, the provinces that had provided the stone and labor used their contribution as leverage. The governor of the western mines demanded permanent control over certain trade routes in exchange for the stone he had supplied. The southern provinces pushed for reduced military oversight at their ports. Both demands were met, not because the ruler agreed with them, but because the alternative was risking their open defiance.

Inside the council, the Minister of Fortifications was removed from his post, but not punished. He returned to his province with his reputation damaged but his alliances intact. His replacement was a man chosen for loyalty rather than competence, a decision that satisfied the ruler's immediate need for control but did nothing to address the structural problems that had led to the collapse in the first place.

Harun recorded that the debate over the minister's removal was the longest he had ever witnessed. Not because the facts were unclear, but because no one wanted to set a precedent for holding powerful allies accountable. The discussion revealed an unspoken truth: the wall was not the only structure built on weak foundations. The same could be said for the empire's political order.

Beyond the capital, the breach was seen as proof that the throne's power was no longer absolute. In the eastern provinces, where the wall had failed, loyalty to the crown weakened. Some towns began dealing directly with neighboring kingdoms for trade and security, bypassing the capital entirely. These arrangements were not openly declared, but they were known. The crown's silence on the matter signaled to others that such deals could be made without consequence.

In private, the ruler blamed the council for the delay in repairs. In public, he praised the provinces for their support, hoping to maintain the appearance of unity. Harun noted the contradiction, writing that the ruler had begun speaking differently in private and public on almost every matter.

By the end of the year, the breach itself had become a political tool. Those loyal to the ruler used it as evidence that reforms were needed to strengthen the central government. His opponents used it as proof that the ruler had lost the ability to govern effectively. The wall had been rebuilt, but the memory of the night it fell remained, a reminder to both allies and rivals that the capital could be reached.

Harun's final note on the matter was blunt. "The breach in the wall was repaired in stone. The breach in authority was left open."

The official archives recorded the breach as a test of resilience, praising the unity of the provinces and the speed of the repairs. It was a version written for the future, stripped of the bargaining, the delays, and the quiet deals made in the shadows.

In reality, the night the walls fell was the night the balance of power shifted. The crown had paid for stone not only in gold but in concessions that would last for years. Governors learned they could withhold support until their price was met. Merchant houses saw that the capital could be forced to negotiate even in matters of security. The throne still stood, but it no longer dictated terms as it once had.

Harun ended his account with a line he never included in the public record: "It is one thing to build a wall. It is another to know who will stand behind it when it falls."

Chapter Eight

Year 53: The Ash and the Orphans

The fire began in the lower quarter, where the wooden houses were built too close together and the streets were too narrow for the palace's fire brigades to move quickly. By the time the first soldiers arrived, the flames had already leapt from one row of houses to the next. Buckets of water were passed hand to hand, but the wind pushed the fire toward the warehouses that stored the city's grain supply.

By nightfall, half the lower quarter was gone. Hundreds were dead, and many more were left with nothing but the clothes they wore. The survivors filled the streets leading to the palace, demanding shelter and food. Some came quietly, others shouting their anger loud enough for the guards at the gate to hear every word.

The ruler was informed before dawn. Harun wrote that he listened to the reports without speaking, his face showing nothing. The fire was a disaster in itself, but the political consequences were more dangerous. The lower quarter was home to the city's largest population of laborers and dock workers. Without them, trade would slow to a crawl. Without food from the warehouses, unrest could spread through the capital in days.

The council met that morning in an emergency session. The Minister of Trade argued that the grain should be distributed immediately to keep the streets calm. The Minister of Finance warned that the reserves were already low and that opening them now could leave the army short in the coming winter. Governors from the provinces offered help, but none without conditions. The western mines wanted reduced taxes on their exports. The southern ports demanded more control over customs inspections.

The debate grew heated, not over how to help the people, but over who would control the aid and profit from its distribution. Harun noted that while the streets outside were filled with smoke and ash, the council chamber was filled with the sound of men calculating advantage.

The ruler broke the deadlock by ordering the grain released, but only enough to last a month. He instructed that it be distributed by soldiers rather than provincial officials. The decision ensured the people saw the aid as coming directly from the crown, but it also deepened the divide between the ruler and the governors. Several left the capital within days, complaining privately that they had been sidelined in front of the city's population.

The orphans were another matter. With entire families wiped out, groups of children wandered the streets. Some were taken in by neighbors, but many were left to fend for themselves. Crime in the lower quarter rose sharply. Gangs began recruiting the older ones, using them as lookouts and thieves. The palace attempted to create an orphan registry, but

few came forward. Many feared that being counted meant being taken for labor in distant provinces.

The political cost came in the form of loyalty lost. The lower quarter had always been a difficult place for the crown to control, but it had also been a place where work and trade tied the people to the empire's stability. After the fire, the relationship changed. The people saw that aid could be delayed, bargained over, and limited. They learned that survival depended more on neighbors than on the council.

In the official record, the fire was called a "great trial" from which the capital emerged stronger. Harun's private account told a different story. "We gave the people bread for a month and left them to rebuild with their own hands. The ashes remained longer than the relief, and the orphans learned quickly who would not come for them."

The rebuilding of the lower quarter became less about restoring the city and more about deciding who would control it. The governors who had been sidelined during the grain distribution saw an opportunity to reclaim influence. They offered to fund the reconstruction, but only if the new housing and markets were built under their authority. The southern ports proposed to rebuild the docks in exchange for exclusive trading rights. The western provinces offered stone for the foundations, demanding in return that all future grain shipments pass through their territories first.

The ruler refused these terms in council, but his position was weaker than it had been before the fire. The treasury was stretched thin, and his soldiers were already deployed to secure trade routes threatened by unrest in the outer provinces. Without provincial support, the rebuilding would take years. With it, the lower quarter could be restored within months but at the cost of surrendering a piece of the capital's independence.

The deadlock played out in full view of the city. Weeks turned into months with little progress. Families camped in the streets where their homes had once stood. Merchants moved their businesses to other districts, leaving the lower quarter without work or trade. The orphans became a permanent presence, forming their own groups that answered to no authority.

Inside the palace, the politics turned even colder. Harun wrote that the fire gave the council a new weapon. Each side began using the slow pace of rebuilding as proof of the other's failure. Supporters of the crown blamed the governors for withholding resources. The governors' allies claimed the ruler had made the situation worse by insisting on complete control. The debate was no longer about the people who had lost everything. It was about who would hold power when the quarter was finally rebuilt.

The turning point came when the governor of the eastern provinces bypassed the palace entirely. Using his own funds, he began rebuilding one section of the lower quarter without royal approval. His builders worked quickly, putting up new structures in less than half the

time the palace had spent debating the matter. The people welcomed the work, and soon parts of the district owed their recovery not to the crown, but to a provincial governor.

This act set a precedent. Other governors followed, each claiming sections of the city as their own projects. What had once been the capital's most unified district became a patchwork of territories, each loyal to whoever had funded their restoration. The ruler still held the palace, but the lower quarter was no longer entirely his.

By the end of Year 53, the fire had done more than destroy buildings. It had given the provinces a foothold in the heart of the capital. Harun's private account was clear on what it meant: "The fire burned the lower quarter, but it was the rebuilding that burned the crown. From this point, the city was no longer whole. The capital became a place divided, and every orphan who grew up in those new streets learned that the empire had many masters."

Chapter Nine

Year 0: The First Shovel of Sand

No one knew at the time that the ceremony would be remembered as the moment the end began. It was called the Renewal Project. The plan was to construct a new central hall beside the palace, a symbol of unity that would house representatives from every province. The ruler presented it as proof that the empire was entering a new era. The council approved it publicly, though in private each minister saw it as a chance to claim their share of the contracts and appointments that would follow.

The ground chosen for the hall had been cleared weeks earlier. Flags from every province hung around the site. Crowds filled the edges, not with the excitement of the old proclamations, but with curiosity and doubt. The city had not forgotten the breaches, the rebellions, and the slow rebuilding of the lower quarter.

The ceremony began with speeches. The ruler spoke first, promising that the hall would stand for generations. Governors took turns praising the vision, each speaking of loyalty and shared purpose. Harun stood among the scribes, recording the words as he had done for decades. He noted how many of them avoided meeting each other's eyes.

When the time came, the ruler stepped forward with a golden-handled shovel. He placed it into the earth and turned the first mound of soil. The crowd cheered, but Harun saw the governors watching the shovel more than the man holding it. For them, the first shovel of sand was not a symbol of unity. It was the signal that the work and the payments could begin.

In the months that followed, the project became a contest of corruption. Contracts for stone, timber, and labor were awarded not to the most skilled builders but to the allies of whoever held influence that week. Supplies meant for the hall were diverted to private estates. Workers went unpaid for months, then abandoned the site entirely. The foundation was dug and left open, filling with stagnant water after the rains.

The council met often, but never to discuss finishing the hall. Instead, they argued over who was to blame for the delays, each side producing documents that accused the other of mismanagement. The ruler's voice carried less weight with each meeting. The provinces had learned that he needed them more than they needed him.

By the end of the year, the construction site was abandoned. The flags had been taken down. The tools rusted in the open air. Weeds grew where the foundation was meant to be. Children from the nearby streets played in the empty pit, unaware that they were standing in the center of a broken promise.

The official record of Year 0 described the Renewal Project as postponed due to “changing priorities.” It did not mention that the first shovel of sand had been the last honest act in the entire venture.

Harun’s final entry in the chronicle was short. “The empire did not fall in a day. It began to sink the moment those who built it forgot what it stood on. The first shovel was not the start of construction. It was the start of the collapse.”

The collapse did not come with a single rebellion or a decisive battle. It came quietly, in the months after the Renewal Project was abandoned. Provincial governors stopped attending council altogether, sending letters instead, each one filled with demands and conditions for even the smallest act of cooperation. Merchant families began funding their own guards to protect trade routes, openly bypassing the crown’s soldiers.

Inside the capital, the palace guard still patrolled the gates, but their presence no longer carried the same weight. Orders from the throne were obeyed in the city out of habit, not loyalty, and beyond the walls they were treated as suggestions. Harun wrote that the council chamber felt like a room where everyone knew the roof was caving in, yet no one wanted to be the first to step outside.

The provinces acted as if the empire had already dissolved, though no one declared it. Trade pacts were made without approval. Laws were enforced differently depending on who controlled the territory. Governors began speaking in public of “regional stability” rather than imperial unity. Even the language of the empire was changing, piece by piece.

In private, the ruler admitted to Harun that he no longer expected to see the hall completed. He spoke less of building and more of holding what remained. The man who had once walked the roads and repaired the bridges now sat in the palace, surrounded by ministers who feared losing what little influence they still had.

By the time Year 0 ended, the empire existed more on paper than in reality. The map had not yet changed, the throne was still occupied, and the banners still hung over the palace gates. But power had moved elsewhere. It was in the hands of those who controlled the ports, the roads, and the grain, and they no longer looked to the crown for permission.

Harun’s last line in the chronicle carried no ceremony and no comfort. “When the first shovel of sand was turned, the ground beneath it had already given way. The rest of us were only waiting to see how long it would take for the walls to follow.”

Closing Note

The events recorded in these pages are not the story of a single ruler's failure. They are the record of how an empire allowed its foundations to weaken while its leaders argued over the shape of the throne. Every breach, every betrayal, every fire, and every abandoned project was treated as an isolated matter, solved in the moment and forgotten. None of it was forgotten by those who gained from it.

The corruption did not come from one place. It came from every level of power. Governors traded loyalty for profit. Merchants traded unity for control of their own routes. Ministers traded truth for survival in the council. The people, left to fend for themselves, learned that the crown was too far away to protect them and too weak to compel obedience.

An empire can survive enemies at its borders. It cannot survive when its core becomes a bargaining table. The throne still stood at the end of Year 0, but it stood alone, no longer the center of authority, only the center of a memory.

This record ends here, not because the story is complete, but because by Year 0 the outcome was certain. The empire would not fall tomorrow or the day after. It had already begun to fall, and the rest was only a matter of time.

The following entries are drawn from the surviving imperial records held in the Central Archives. They appear here in the order in which they were catalogued, not in the sequence in which events occurred. Some files referenced remain sealed. Others are missing entirely. The wording of each entry is presented without alteration.

Archival Timeline Document

CENTRAL ARCHIVES

Document Reference: 1184-CHRON/52 Clearance Level: Internal
Status: Unsealed for Public Record After Review

TIMILINE OF RECORDED EVENTS

Year 47 – The Poison Banquet

Incident Report NO. 47/19

Multiple high-ranking officials fall ill during banquet.
Cause Officially attributed to contaminated wine. Unofficial notes
Indicate suspect of deliberate contamination.

Year 2 – The Birth of the Builder

Record ID: INFEA/2/04

Military officer appointed to oversee infrastructure repair in two
provinces. Rapid signs of provincial allegiance shifts noted.

Year 51 – The Great Betrayal

Case File 51/08

Two provinces declare separation from imperial governance. Materials
redirected to private estates. Early signs of provin.

Year 53 – The Disappearance of the Bridge

Archive Ref: COMMERCE/33/12

A major bridge dismantled under guise of safety concerns. Emerging
figure in governance leverages instability to centralize personal
influence.

Year 1 – The Sand Beneath Us

Security Memo: GOV/1/15

Foundations of central authority under review. Emerging figure in
governance leverages instability to centralize personal influence.

Year 52 – The Night the Walls Fell

Incident Log: DEF/52/03

Eastern wall breach due to structural neglect. Rebuilding efforts
hindered by disputes over jurisdiction. Increase.

Year 0 – The First Shovel of Sand

Project Report: RENEWAL/0/01

Symbolic unification project announced. Mismanagement and corrup-
tion. Gate abandoned. Marking final recorded moment of centr.

About the Author

Sonia Benjoye is the author of multiple works of fiction and nonfiction, known for writing intense, character-driven stories that explore human behavior and the choices people make under pressure.

Her books cover a wide range of themes, from personal survival and relationships to power, truth, and the consequences of secrets. Sonia's work is built on sharp observation, grounded storytelling, and an unflinching approach to human complexity.

She continues to write and publish independently, connecting directly with her readers and building a body of work that challenges, engages, and stays with them long after the last page.

Other Works by Sonia Benjoye

- *Nothing Stays Hidden*
- *What It Took*
- *The Paradox of Passion*
- *Woman. Weapon. Work.*
- *This Is the Season for Guts*
- *God Was Never the Problem*
- *Mother. Monster. Machine.*
- *Black Veins, Open Mouth*
- *Her Hand Held the Future, Her Back Held the Weight*
- *The Beautiful Discipline of Boredom*
- *This Is How She Ended the World*
- *Blackout City*

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